traitors. At times the reaction was surprisingly hostile and some of the players were worried about their safety.

Headlines like ‘Endulkar’ hurt deeply. After eighteen years in international cricket, it was tough to see things come to this and retirement crossed my mind. My family and friends like Sanjay Nayak did all they could to cheer me up and after a week I decided to do something about it. I started to do some running, to try to sweat the World Cup out of my head.

On top of all this our coach, Greg Chappell, was publicly questioning our commitment and instead of asking us to take fresh guard, was making matters worse. It seems to me that Greg Chappell must take a lot of responsibility for the mess. I don’t think I would be far off the mark if I said that most of us felt that Indian cricket was going nowhere under Chappell.

In my opinion, Indian cricket benefited significantly when the BCCI decided to end Chappell’s tenure in April 2007. Several of our senior players were relieved to see him go, which was hardly surprising because, for reasons hard to comprehend, he had not treated them particularly fairly. His attitude to Sourav, for example, was astonishing. Chappell is on record as saying that he may have got the job because of Sourav but that did not mean he was going to do favours to Sourav for the rest of his life. Frankly, Sourav is one of the best cricketers India has produced and he did not need favours from Chappell to be part of the team.

Chappell seemed intent on dropping all the older players and in the process damaged the harmony of the side. On one occasion, he asked VVS Laxman to consider opening the batting. Laxman politely turned him down, saying he had tried opening in the first half of his career because he was confused, but now he was settled in the middle order and Greg should consider him as a middle-order batsman. Greg’s response stunned us all. He told Laxman he should be careful, because making a comeback at the age of thirty-two might not be easy.

Unlike John Wright and Gary Kirsten, who coached India before and after Greg and made a priority of keeping the players happy, Greg was like a ringmaster who imposed his ideas on the players without showing any signs of being concerned about whether they felt comfortable or not. In fact, I later found out that Greg had spoken to the BCCI about the need to remove the senior players, no doubt hoping to refresh the team.